Milan Mossé

milan_mosse at stanford.edu
mmosse19.github.io
+1 (626) 710-2177

Employment

Embedded Ethics Fellow, Stanford University 2026-current
The McCoy Family Center for Ethics in Society &
The Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence

Areas

Specialization: Ethics and Political Philosophy (including AI)

Competence: Philosophy of Action, Language, Race, and Science; Logic

Education

Ph.D., Philosophy, University of California, Berkeley 2026
Dissertation: *Reasons by Request*
Committee: Johann Frick (co-chair), R. Jay Wallace (co-chair), Anna Stilz

M.S., Computer Science, Stanford University 2024
Research supervisors: Thomas Icard, Omer Reingold, Li-Yang Tan

B.A., Philosophy (Honors) & B.S., Mathematics, Stanford University 2020
Thesis advisors: Michael Bratman, Barry Maguire

Peer-reviewed publications

Google Scholar PhilPapers

How Requests Create Reasons 2026
Philosophy & Phenomenological Research

Stable Voting and the Splitting of Cycles 2026
Association for the Advancement of Artificial Intelligence
Wesley H. Holliday, Milan Mossé, Chase Norman, Eric Pacuit, Cynthia Wang

How to Count Sore Throats 2025
Analysis
Léa Bourguignon, Milan Mossé

On Probabilistic and Causal Reasoning with Summation Operators 2025
Journal of Logic and Computation
Duligur Ibeling, Thomas Icard, Milan Mossé

Social Choice for AI Alignment: Dealing with Diverse Human Feedback 2024
International Conference on Machine Learning
Vincent Conitzer, Rachel Freedman, Jobst Heitzig, Wesley Holliday, Bob Jacobs, Nathan Lambert, Milan Mossé, Eric Pacuit, Stuart Russell, Hailey Schoelkopf, Emanuel Tewolde, William Zwicker

Probing the Quantitative-Qualitative Divide in Probabilistic Reasoning 2024
Annals of Pure and Applied Logic
Duligur Ibeling, Thomas Icard, Krzysztof Mierzewski, Milan Mossé

Is Causal Reasoning Harder than Probabilistic Reasoning? 2024
Review of Symbolic Logic
Milan Mossé, Duligur Ibeling, Thomas Icard

Multiplicative Metric Fairness Under Composition 2023
Foundations of Responsible Computing

A Generalization of the Satisfiability Coding Lemma and Its Applications 2022
International Conference on Theory and Applications of Satisfiability Testing
Milan Mossé, Harry Sha, Li-Yang Tan (Best Theory Paper Award)

Conditional Negative Sampling for Contrastive Learning of Visual Representations 2021
International Conference on Machine Learning
Mike Wu, Milan Mossé, Chengxu Zhuang, Daniel Yamins, Noah Goodman

Zero Shot Learning for Code Education: Rubric Sampling with Deep Learning Inference 2019
Association for the Advancement of Artificial Intelligence
Mike Wu, Milan Mossé, Noah Goodman, Chris Piech (Outstanding Student Paper Award)

Under revision

Why Not Ask?
R&R, *Ethics*

Modeling Discrimination with Causal Abstraction
R&R, *Philosophers' Imprint*
Milan Mossé, Kara Schechtman, Frederick Eberhardt, Thomas Icard
Best Paper Nomination, FAccT 2026

Individualism and Its Limits
R&R, Noûs
Léa Bourguignon, Jonas Harney, Milan Mossé

Giving Grace
Invited to submit to *Oxford Studies in Normative Ethics*

Why AI Alignment Needs Moral Foundations
Invited to submit to *Philosophy & Technology*

Edited volume

Limited Aggregation, *Philosophical Studies* 2028 (expected)
Guest editor, with Léa Bourguignon & Jonas Harney

Awards & fellowships

Best Paper Nomination, Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency 2026

Graduate Fellow, Kavli Center for Ethics, Science, and the Public, UC Berkeley 2024-25

Dissertation Completion Fellowship, UC Berkeley 2025

Outstanding Graduate Student Instructor Award (<10% of TAs), UC Berkeley 2023

Cota Robles Fellowship, UC Berkeley 2020

Best Theory Paper, Conference on Satisfiability Testing 2022

Outstanding Student Paper, Association for the Advancement of Artificial Intelligence 2019

Major Grant, Stanford 2019

Mellon Mays Undergraduate Fellow, Stanford 2017-19

Chappell-Lougee Scholarship, Stanford 2017

Selected presentations

Betting on Misfortune (with Johann Frick)
- The Normative Foundations of the Market, University of Pennsylvania* 2027

Corruption as the Devaluation of Membership (with Eliza Wells)
- Central APA Colloquium 2027

Giving Grace
- Arizona Workshop in Normative Ethics 2027
- Philosophy Forum, UC Berkeley* 2026

How Questions Structure Plans (with Seth Yalcin; various titles)
- 5th Annual Conference of the Philosophy of Language Association, UCLA 2026
- Planning Workshop, Stanford University* 2026
- Eastern APA Symposium* 2026
- Agency and Intentions in Language, Harvey Mudd College 2024

Individualism and Its Limits
- Rocky Mountain Ethics Congress, University of Colorado Boulder 2026
- Choice Group, London School of Economics* 2026
- Workshop on Moral Aggregation, University of Manchester 2025

Modeling Discrimination with Causal Abstraction (with Kara Schechtman)
- To Be or Not to Be Included in a Causal Model, University of Pittsburgh 2026
- Departmental Talk, Emory University* 2025
- CEPDISC, Aarhus University 2024
- Stanford Logic Seminar* 2024

How Requests Create Reasons
- Berkeley-London Conference 2026

Eastern APA Symposium 2026

Reasoning about Confirmation
Probability Logic Workshop, Carnegie Mellon University 2025

Why Not Ask? (various titles)
Central APA Symposium 2025
Rocky Mountain Ethics Congress, University of Colorado Boulder 2024

*invited; all others via application

Teaching

University of California, Berkeley

Co-Instructor, Individual Morality and Social Justice, with Russell McIntosh Summer 2024

TA, Philosophy of Science, with Ezra Rubenstein Fall 2025

TA, Political Philosophy: Equality and Identity, with Véronique Munoz-Dardé Fall 2024

TA, Political Philosophy, with Véronique Munoz-Dardé Fall 2023

TA, Contemporary Ethical Issues, with Tim Crockett Summer 2023

TA, Bioethics, with Johann Frick Fall 2022

TA, Philosophy of Race, Ethnicity, and Citizenship, with Tim Crockett Summer 2022

TA, Individual Morality and Social Justice, with Johann Frick Spring 2022

TA, Nature of Mind, with John Campbell Fall 2021

Stanford University

TA, Incentives in Computer Science, with Aviad Rubenstein Spring 2024

TA, Design and Analysis of Algorithms, with Karey Shi Summer 2020

TA, Design and Analysis of Algorithms, with Mary Wootters Winter 2020

TA, Programming Abstractions, with Marty Stepp Winter 2018

TA, Programming Methodology, with Mehran Sahami Fall 2018

Service

Diversity, equity, and inclusion

Graduate Representative, Equity Task Force, Focus on Trans Inclusion 2021-22, 2024-25

Co-Organizer, Minorities and Philosophy 2021-22, 2023-24

Co-Organizer, COMPASS Workshop Fall 2022

Un-Naming Proposal Co-Author, Moses Hall Name Review Committee Spring 2021

Other organizing, chairing, and refereeing

Organizer, Job Market Materials Workshop	Summer 2025, 2026
Co-Organizer, MANCEPT Limited Aggregation Workshop	Fall 2025
Founder, Co-Organizer, & Mentor, Directed Reading Program	Spring 2022, 2023, 2025
Organizer, Graduate Work-in-Progress Talks	2020-21, 2023-2024
Grad Organizer, Social Choice for AI Ethics & Safety Workshop	Spring 2023
Grad Organizer, Department Colloquia	2022-23
Organizer, Faculty Work-in-Progress Talks	Spring 2021/2023, 2023-24
Organizer, Latin American Philosophy Reading Group	Spring 2022
Organizer, Feminism and Masculinity Reading Group	2021-22

Referee: Computational Complexity Conference; Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems (×9); International Conference on Machine Learning (×5); International Colloquium on Automata, Languages and Programming; International Symposium on Algorithms and Computation; Journal of Logic and Computation; Journal of Moral Philosophy (×5); Logic Journal of the IGPL (×3); Noûs; Philosophical Studies (×2); Philosophy; Philosophy & Technology; Review of Symbolic Logic; Symposium on Discrete Algorithms; Thought; Utilitas

Skills

Languages: Spanish (professional proficiency) and German (reading) *Coding*: C, C++, Python

References

Johann Frick
Associate Professor of Philosophy
University of California, Berkeley
jfrick@berkeley.edu

Thomas F. Icard
C. I. Lewis Professor of Philosophy and (by courtesy) Professor of Computer Science
Stanford University
icard@stanford.edu

Véronique Munoz-Dardé (teaching reference)
Professor of Philosophy
University College London
Mills Adjunct Professor of Philosophy
University of California, Berkeley
munoz_darde@berkeley.edu

R. Jay Wallace
William & Trudy Ausfahl Chair in Philosophy
University of California, Berkeley
rjw@berkeley.edu

Seth Yalcin
Professor of Philosophy
University of California, Berkeley
yalcin@berkeley.edu

Reasons by Request

Dissertation Summary

You are not required to stop and aid every stranger you encounter. Seeing a lost tourist, you can permissibly decide not to help, thinking to yourself, "I'll help the next time I see someone in their shoes." But this thought rings hollow when the lost stranger *requests* your help. Your normative situation has changed. You must now cite a reason for not helping or else provide assistance. Requesters wield what is, on reflection, a remarkable power: to create reasons at will. The central puzzle of requests is to explain how this is possible. How can requesters give us reasons to do what they want, even when they stand in no relation of authority over us? And what would be lost if we saw requests as merely reminding us of reasons that exist already, rather than creating new ones?

My dissertation begins by explaining how requests create reasons. At the center of my account is the idea that we have reasons to grant requests when and because doing so improves our compliance with our duties. For example, we have a duty of mutual aid, but because this duty gives us the discretion to decide exactly when and how we will help others, we are liable to fall short of it, by repeatedly postponing compliance. When a lost stranger asks you for help, their request gives you a reason *here* and *now* to help *this person*. The concrete nature of the request makes it harder to keep postponing your duty of mutual aid. In general, requests create reasons because they thereby help us to comply better with our flexible moral duties.

I next consider how the values served by the power to request constrain its permissible use: What do we owe to the recipients of our requests? I approach this question by way of an asymmetry between requests and offers. It is often not okay to request an act, but perfectly fine to accept an offer for it. What might explain this? After all, the request and offer result in the same duty upon their acceptance, and they concern the same act. I argue that some requests are wrongful *precisely because they create reasons*. Creating a reason often generates a double-bind for the requestee: if they act as requested, they pay the practical cost of doing so; if they do not, they pay a moral cost, in the form of a reason for regret. While this double-bind does not always make requests wrongful, I show how it can be intrusive, manipulative, and coercive. Offers do not create the same double-bind, I argue, because offers do not as such create reasons.

I turn, finally, to a foundational question: How can the power to create a reason by requesting be explained *by its value*? It does not in general follow from the fact that it would be good for us to possess an ability that we do possess it: it would be good if we could fly like birds, but we can't. Hence there is a worry that my account of requests, along with several prominent value-based explanations of requests, promises, and commands, rests on a fallacious form of wishful thinking. I argue that the power to create reasons by requesting can be justified by comparing its value *for each person:* a person possesses this power when, in general, it is better for *requesters* in these circumstances to *possess* the power than it would be for *requestees* to *not be subject* to the power. I generalize my account to show how commands and promises can be justified, and I argue my view does not rest on wishful thinking, but rather on a familiar and widely-accepted form of explanation in ethics, which justifies normative principles by considering what the world would be like for each of us, were those principles generally accepted.